

The Architecture of the Face

The bones, muscles, and proportions beneath every brushstroke — and why they are a guide, never a rule

Learning Objectives

- Name the bone and muscle landmarks a makeup artist references when placing product
- Identify the six classic face shapes and the proportions that define each
- Explain facial proportion guidelines as artistic tools, not universal standards of beauty
- Explain why every makeup service begins with the same skin philosophy taught in Course I

Before colour, structure

Makeup is often taught as a conversation about colour first — which shade, which finish, which trend. At the Amber Atelier, it begins somewhere quieter: the structure beneath the colour. Every contour, highlight, and blended edge you will ever place answers to the bone and muscle underneath it, whether the client's face is round or angular, still or animated in conversation. Understanding that structure is what separates artistry from decoration.

You are not painting a flat surface. You are shading a structure that moves, speaks, and ages. Respect the architecture, and the colour takes care of itself.

The landmarks beneath the skin

- **The frontal bone** — the forehead's structure, setting the brow's natural arch height.
- **The zygomatic bones (cheekbones)** — the primary landmark for highlight and contour placement; their prominence and angle vary enormously and should never be assumed from a single reference photo.

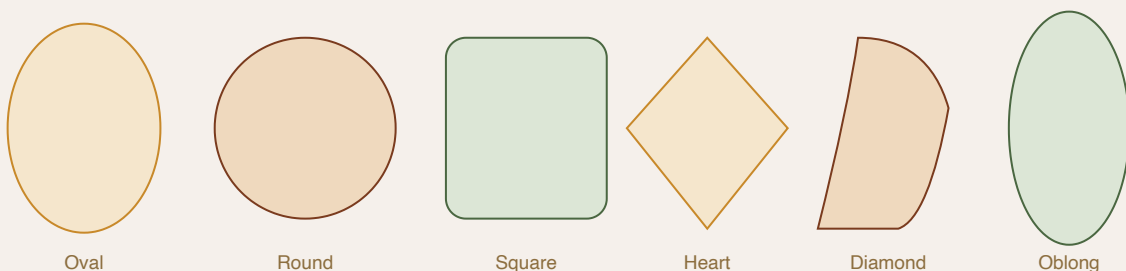
- **The nasal bone and cartilage** — governs where nose contouring reads as natural versus obviously drawn-on.
- **The mandible (jawline)** — the lower boundary of the face, and the structure most commonly softened or sharpened through contour.
- **Orbicularis oculi and orbicularis oris** — the ring muscles circling the eyes and mouth, responsible for blinking, smiling, and speaking. Product applied without accounting for their movement is the most common reason eyeshadow creases or lip colour migrates within an hour.

The six classic face shapes

Face-shape classification is a widely taught artistic shorthand, useful for deciding where to place light and shadow — not a system for sorting clients into categories of correctness.

- **Oval** — length roughly one and a half times the width, with a jaw slightly narrower than the forehead. Traditionally treated as the "balanced" reference shape, though every shape below is equally balanced in its own right.
- **Round** — width and length are close to equal, with soft, curved edges and fuller cheeks.
- **Square** — a strong, angular jawline roughly equal in width to the forehead.
- **Heart** — a wider forehead narrowing to a pointed chin.
- **Diamond** — narrow forehead and jawline with the cheekbones as the widest point.
- **Oblong** — noticeably longer than it is wide, with a straighter cheek line.

◆ Figure 1.1 · The Six Face Shapes



Six classic reference shapes — a vocabulary for placing light and shadow, never a hierarchy of correctness.

Proportion guidelines, held loosely

Classical art historically divided the face into equal thirds (hairline to brow, brow to nose base, nose base to chin) and fifths (the width of one eye repeated five times across the face). These remain useful for judging balance in editorial and bridal work. They are not, and were never intended as, a scientific measure of beauty — a face that departs from these proportions is not a face requiring correction. Use the guideline to inform your eye. Never use it to inform a client that her face needs fixing.

The skin underneath never stops mattering

Every principle from Course I remains true the moment makeup enters the conversation.

Makeup sits on skin, interacts with its oil production, its barrier, its sensitivities — it does not replace any of that biology. A foundation chosen without reference to the skin type taught in Course I will separate, cake, or trigger congestion within hours, however perfectly it was colour-matched. Architecture and colour theory are this course's new material. The skin itself is not.

Key Terms

0

[object Object]

1

[object Object]

2

[object Object]

3

[object Object]

Practical Activity · Map the Structure

On a partner or in a mirror, gently locate and lightly mark (with a washable cosmetic pencil) the key bone landmarks from this module, then identify the face shape using the proportion guidelines taught. Photograph the marked face. **Keep this photograph — it opens your capstone portfolio in Module Fifteen.**